PRIORITY CHECK

Incident Priority Assignment Framework

Impact × Urgency = Priority

AGENDA

01

Objective

Framework overview & goal

02

Priority Matrix

P1–P4 classification table

03

Priority Distribution

Impact vs Urgency charts

04

Urgency Factors

Key drivers that elevate priority

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Decision Point

Response, escalation & comms

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Recording & SLA timer requirements

07

SLA Targets

Response & resolution benchmarks

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Key Takeaways

Summary & action points

OBJECTIVE

Assign incident priority based on a structured evaluation of

IMPACT × URGENCY

IMPACT

The breadth and depth of effect on business operations, users, and services.

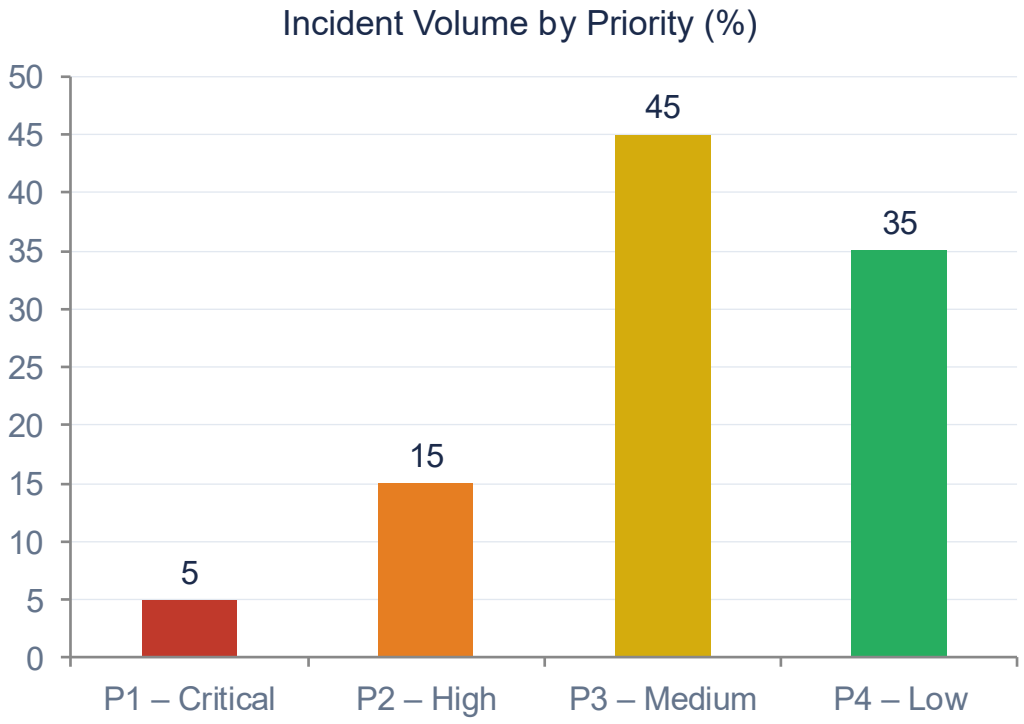
URGENCY

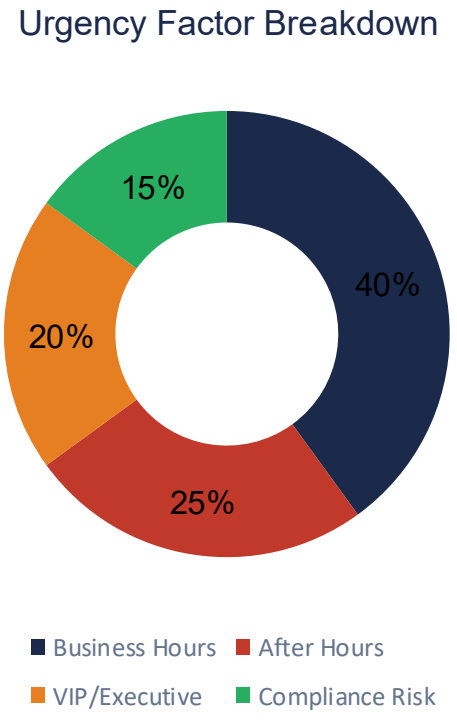
How quickly resolution is required to prevent further damage or escalation.

PRIORITY MATRIX

Priority	Impact	Urgency	Example Scenarios
P1 – Critical	High	High	Production outage, security breach, data loss
P2 – High	Medium / High	Medium / High	Major degradation, partial outage, VIP impact
P3 – Medium	Medium	Low / Medium	Minor degradation, workaround available
P4 – Low	Low	Low	Cosmetic issue, low-impact request, general query

PRIORITY DISTRIBUTION — IMPACT vs URGENCY





URGENCY FACTORS

Business Hours vs After Hours

Incidents occurring outside business hours may require higher urgency rating due to limited support availability and extended impact window.

Executive or VIP Impact

Any incident affecting C-suite executives, VIPs, or board members automatically elevates urgency regardless of technical scope.

Regulatory or Compliance Risk

Incidents violating GDPR, HIPAA, PCI-DSS, or other regulatory frameworks require immediate escalation due to legal exposure.

Customer SLA Penalties

Breaches of committed SLA response or resolution times trigger financial penalties and reputational damage.

DECISION POINT

Priority drives three critical dimensions of incident response:

Response Time	Escalation Speed	Communication Cadence
P1: ≤ 15 minutes	P1: Immediate exec alert	P1: Every 15 min update
P2: ≤ 1 hour	P2: Manager notified	P2: Every 30 min update
P3: ≤ 4 hours	P3: Team lead aware	P3: Every 2 hours
P4: ≤ 1 business day	P4: Standard ticket queue	P4: Resolution update only

DOCUMENTATION REQUIREMENTS

01

Record Priority in Ticket

Assign and document the priority level (P1–P4) immediately upon incident triage. Include the rationale explaining why this priority was selected based on impact and urgency assessment.

02

Document Justification

Record the specific Impact and Urgency scores. Note which urgency factors applied (after hours, VIP, compliance risk, SLA penalties). This is critical for post-incident review.

03

Trigger SLA Timers

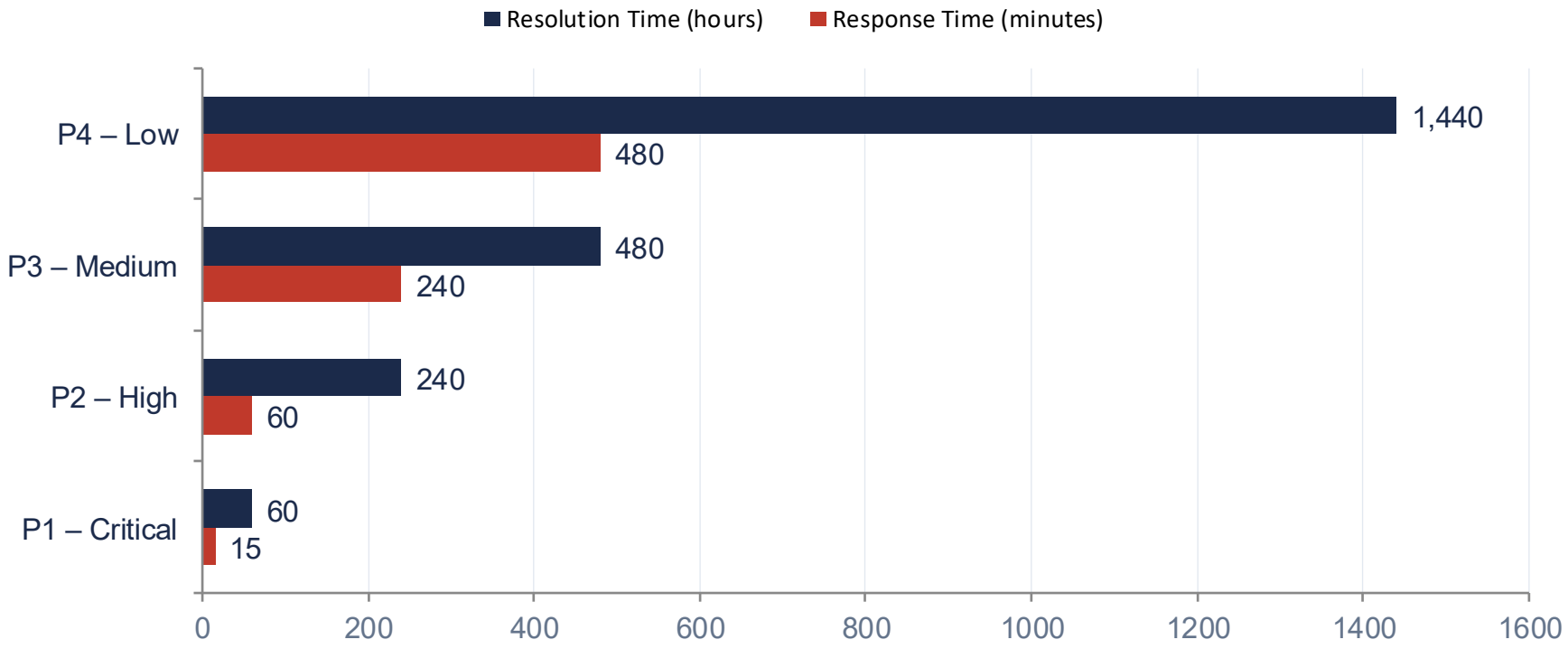
Ensure ITSM tooling (ServiceNow, Jira, Freshservice, etc.) has automatically started the appropriate SLA clock. Verify the timer reflects the correct priority-based response commitment.

04

Maintain Audit Trail

Any priority changes during the incident lifecycle must be logged with timestamp, changed-by, and reason. This supports post-incident analysis and compliance audits.

SLA RESPONSE & RESOLUTION TARGETS



KEY TAKEAWAYS

1. Priority = Impact × Urgency. Always evaluate both dimensions before assigning.
2. P1 and P2 require immediate action: escalate, communicate, and resolve fast.
3. Urgency modifiers (after-hours, VIP, compliance, SLA) can elevate priority.
4. Every incident must have documented priority with a clear justification.
5. SLA timers must trigger automatically. Verify in your ITSM tool upon assignment.
6. Post-incident reviews should validate whether priorities were correctly assigned.